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CHARTER GUIDE

Best Anchorages Between Estepona and Cabopino

A skipper's guide to nine sheltered anchorages along the 28 NM of coast between Estepona and Cabopino, with depths, holding notes and wind windows for planning a half-day or full-day charter from Puerto Banús.

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The strip at a glance

The 28 nautical miles between Estepona marina and Cabopino hold roughly a dozen workable anchorages, and on a good summer day you can string three of them into a single charter. This guide is the skipper-side view: where the sand actually lies, which bays die first in a Levante, and how long the runs really take from Puerto Banús. All distances are measured from the Banús harbour mouth.

Think of the coast as three zones. West of Puerto Banús (Guadalmina, San Pedro, Estepona) gives you Poniente shelter and quieter water in August. East of Banús (Río Verde, Marbella, Cala del Faro, Cabopino) has the cleaner sand and the dramatic lighthouse-and-dune backdrop. The middle, Banús itself, is the busiest mile of coast in Andalusia between June and September, so we treat it as transit rather than swim water.

ANCHORAGE	FROM BANÚS (NM)	DEPTH (M)	BEST WIND
Estepona Bay	10 W	5-8	Levante
Guadalmina	4 W	4-6	Light any
Río Verde	1.5 E	4-6	Light Poniente
Levante Beach	0.5 E	4-5	Light Poniente
Marbella roadstead	4 E	5-7	Poniente
Cala del Faro	2 E	5-7	Poniente
Cabopino / Cala Cortés	8 E	4-8	Poniente

Cala del Faro, the safe default

Two nautical miles east of Banús, tucked under the Marbella lighthouse cliffs, this is the bay we go to nine times out of ten on a Tier A charter. Sand bottom in 5-7 m, holding is excellent on a Danforth, and the cliff to the north breaks any breeze under about 18 kts of Poniente. Water clears up by 0900 most mornings and you can usually see your anchor on the bottom. It is also the closest swimmable anchorage to Banús, which matters on a 2-hour booking.



— The Astondoa 40, a Tier A boat and the usual choice for a Cala del Faro swim stop.

SECTION 03

Cabopino and Cala Cortés, the clearest water

Eight NM east, past the Marbella sewage outfall and the Río Real, you cross a clean line: visibility jumps to 8-12 m and the seabed turns to white sand backed by the protected Artola dunes. Anchor in 4-8 m about 300 m off the beach, outside the swim-zone buoys. Cabopino marina is two minutes away if you want a long lunch ashore. This is the obvious destination for a full-day 8h charter on the Astondoa 40 or Azimut 39.

SECTION 04

Quick stops and the Levante backup

If you have 90 minutes of swim time and the wind is light, the bays immediately east of Banús work fine. Río Verde at 1.5 NM holds in 4-6 m on sand with patches of weed, and your skipper picks the patch. Levante Beach, just outside the breakwater, is the closest possible stop but gets busy with charter tenders and jet skis from noon onwards. We use it mainly as a calm-weather warm-up before pushing east.

When the easterly fills in above 15 kts, the eastern bays turn into a short, ugly chop on a lee shore and we run west. The roadstead immediately east of Estepona marina sits under Punta de la Plata and stays workable up to about 20 kts of Levante. Holding is sand in 5-8 m. The run from Banús is 10 NM, which is 28 minutes at 22 kts on a Pershing 46 or a Mangusta 80, slightly longer on the Tier A boats.

Anchorage we skip, and reading the day

The Guadalmina and Río Verde mouths after heavy rain drop visibility to nothing for a day or two. The stretch directly off San Pedro has more weed than the chart suggests and worse holding than it looks. The kilometre of water east of Marbella marina sits over the municipal outfall, fine to transit but not somewhere we drop the hook. None of this shows up on a basic chart plot, which is why local skipper knowledge matters more than the app.

The forecast call gets made at the dock. We look at three numbers: wind direction, wind strength at 1500 (the daily peak), and swell period. Anything under 12 kts and you can pick anywhere on the strip. At 12-18 kts we pick the lee side, east bays for Poniente and west bays for Levante. Above 18 kts we either tuck deep into Cala del Faro or Estepona Bay, or shorten the day. We do not push weather windows on charter; it is your day off, not a delivery.

How many stops fit in a day

On a 2-hour Tier A charter (€749 all-in) you get one stop, almost always Cala del Faro. On 4 hours, two stops, typically Río Verde plus Cala del Faro, or Cala del Faro plus a quick Cabopino tease. On the full 8-hour day at €2,299 you can string Estepona Bay or Guadalmina in the morning, Cala del Faro for lunch on board, and Cabopino in the afternoon. The Mangusta 80 at €4,719 for 4 hours covers the same ground 25% faster and lets you skip further down to Sotogrande if you want.

Plan transits at 18-22 kts and budget 45 minutes per swim stop minimum, otherwise it feels rushed. Bigger or different boats, such as the Pershing 46, Ferretti 94 and Canados 86, are priced on request.



— The Azimut 39 covers the full Estepona to Cabopino strip comfortably on an 8-hour day.

What is included on every anchor stop

- ✦ Licensed Spanish skipper who actually knows these bays
- ✦ Fuel for the whole charter, no surcharge
- ✦ Water, soft drinks, beer, white wine, cava on ice
- ✦ Light snacks aboard
- ✦ Towels, snorkel masks, paddle board on most boats
- ✦ Full insurance and safety equipment, Spanish IVA (21%)

The drinks list is honest and unlimited within reason, with no hidden bar bill at the end. The skipper sets the hook with reverse thrust and stays aboard the whole time you swim, and there is no anchoring inside swim-zone buoy lines, which run 200 m off most beaches.

Plan your day on the water

Read more skipper-written guides and book your Marbella charter at boatrentalinmarbella.com. Tier A boats from €749 for 2 hours, skipper, fuel, drinks and IVA included.

Boat owners: list your boat free and reach charter guests worldwide at boathire24.com.

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